

# Applying an Action Mapping Lens

## Retrospective Performance-Focused Analysis of a 10-Week Learning Programme

Performance goal · Required actions · Practice activities · Supporting knowledge

Applied retrospectively to original programme-design work completed as part of the Cambridge DELTA diploma.

## Action Mapping at a glance

| PERFORMANCE GOAL   | REQUIRED ACTIONS       | PRACTICE                 | SUPPORTING KNOWLEDGE       |
|--------------------|------------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------|
| What must improve? | What must learners do? | What lets them practise? | What do they need to know? |

## Purpose of this lens

The original programme was not designed using Action Mapping terminology. This portfolio artefact applies a performance-focused lens retrospectively to show how the documented learning need, learner actions, practice activities and supporting knowledge can be connected. The analysis stays within evidence contained in the original needs analysis, diagnostic testing, course proposal and 10-week course plan.

## Programme evidence base

| AUDIENCE               | DURATION             | BASELINE            | TARGET CONTEXT     |
|------------------------|----------------------|---------------------|--------------------|
| 10 learners aged 16-17 | 10 x 2-hour sessions | 43.6% class average | FCE Use of English |

## What this lens asks

- Start with the performance learners need to improve, not with a list of content to cover.
- Identify the actions learners must be able to carry out successfully in the target context.
- Use realistic practice so learners rehearse those actions rather than only receive information.
- Keep supporting knowledge focused on what helps successful performance.

# The programme through an Action Mapping lens

Each stage below separates the desired performance from the actions, practice and knowledge documented in the original programme design.

|                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>1</p> <p><b>PERFORMANCE GOAL</b></p>     | <p><b>What performance needed to improve?</b></p> <p>Strengthen learners' ability to complete FCE Use of English tasks accurately and strategically under examination conditions. The course priorities focused on improving task technique, concentration, language accuracy and performance in the weaker test sections.</p> <p><b>Action Mapping value:</b> Define success in terms of learner performance rather than content coverage.</p>                                       |
| <p>2</p> <p><b>REQUIRED ACTIONS</b></p>     | <p><b>What did learners need to be able to do?</b></p> <p>Read and understand rubrics, recognise language in context, predict likely answers, discriminate between options, break tasks into logical stages, manipulate word forms and sentence structures, and apply strategies under timed conditions.</p> <p><b>Action Mapping value:</b> Translate a broad goal into observable actions learners can practise.</p>                                                                |
| <p>3</p> <p><b>PRACTICE ACTIVITIES</b></p>  | <p><b>What gave learners repeated practice?</b></p> <p>Staged exam tasks, timed practice, pair and group problem-solving, peer checking, learner-generated questions and stories, strategy review, communicative games and a full practice test. Activities moved from guided work towards more independent application.</p> <p><b>Action Mapping value:</b> Make practice resemble the decisions and actions required in the target performance.</p>                                 |
| <p>4</p> <p><b>SUPPORTING KNOWLEDGE</b></p> | <p><b>What knowledge supported those actions?</b></p> <p>Examination format, rubrics and marking expectations; grammar and lexis in context; tense and verb forms; word classes; prepositions; collocations; phrasal verbs; and common task conventions. Knowledge was selected because it supported identified learner needs and task performance.</p> <p><b>Action Mapping value:</b> Treat information as support for action, not as the end point of the learning experience.</p> |

## What the Action Mapping lens reveals

Viewed through this lens, the programme is strongest where practice is tied directly to actions learners need in the examination. Grammar, lexis and exam knowledge function as performance support, while repeated guided and timed activities give learners opportunities to apply strategies in context.

## Action-to-practice alignment

| REQUIRED ACTION                         | PRACTICE ACTIVITY                                          | SUPPORTING KNOWLEDGE                                           |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Interpret task instructions and rubrics | Strategy review, task staging and guided exam practice     | Exam format, marking and task conventions                      |
| Predict and discriminate from context   | Cloze tasks, mixed-up texts, pair reasoning and feedback   | Context clues, lexical relationships and collocations          |
| Manipulate language accurately          | Word-formation, transformation and learner-generated tasks | Word classes, tense/verb forms, prepositions and phrasal verbs |
| Perform under time pressure             | Timed tasks and the Week 9 full practice test              | Task strategy, concentration and pacing                        |

## What this demonstrates

|                                            |                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Performance-focused learning design</b> | <b>Alignment of goals, actions and practice</b>    |
| <b>Scenario and activity selection</b>     | <b>Needs-based content prioritisation</b>          |
| <b>Practice-centred programme design</b>   | <b>Retrospective instructional-design analysis</b> |

## Retrospective reflection

The original DELTA project did not state that Action Mapping was used. Applying the framework retrospectively highlights a useful distinction: the course was most effective when learners were asked to practise the actions needed for successful performance, with language knowledge and exam information serving those actions. A redesign today could make that performance-first logic even more explicit from the outset.

### EVIDENCE BOUNDARY

The original documents support the learning need, required actions, course activities, language priorities and in-programme assessment described here. They do not document long-term transfer or post-course business impact, so those outcomes are not claimed in this artefact.

Evidence base: original Cambridge DELTA extended assignment, Teaching Examination Classes: Preparing Students for the FCE Use of English Test, and the associated 10-week FCE Use of English Course Plan.